

Danish Philosophers

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Introduction

A small country such as ours lies open to influences from without. The spiritual currents from the great centres of culture reach decisively into its intellectual life, and this life cannot attain that firm continuity through the ages which becomes possible when a country is able to bring forth a great multiplicity of thinking minds — minds that never let development come to a standstill and that, through the various types they present, can break the influences coming from abroad, so that the continuity in a people's intellectual life may be the better preserved.

Nevertheless, serious and independent thought has been devoted here at home to the questions that it is philosophy's calling to discuss — the presuppositions of science, the significance of its results for one's view of life, the foundation of ethical evaluation, the nature and laws of the human spirit, the relation between religion and humanity. The influences from without have been assimilated in a distinctive way, and our national character has shown itself in the manner in which the problems have been treated. In the treatment of such questions as those mentioned, which lie on the borders between strict science and life, the personalities of the thinkers must necessarily contribute in a higher degree than in other inquiries. And where personality operates according to its whole distinctiveness, the national traits too assert themselves. For these are not layers or pieces joined from without to the other qualities of individuals, but determine those qualities from the very first and sound along with them, every time the strings of the mind are struck.

That Danish thought has its own distinctive character can be seen by comparison with Swedish thought. Sweden's intellectual life has received the same currents from abroad as Denmark's, but in the domain of thought these have been assimilated and developed in another way and in another direction than with us. Speculation and mysticism have played a far greater role in Sweden than in Denmark, and, bound up with this, an urge toward systematic completeness has asserted itself there which has never found firm ground with us. Danish thought has been essentially borne by a psychological and ethical interest, and again and again a level-headed criticism has made itself felt against

the construction of systems.¹ Among our foremost thinking minds (Holberg, the Ørstedes, Sibbern, Kierkegaard) this distinctive character makes itself felt, and it gives rise to thoughts and works which, though they have not entered into the great international discussion of the questions of knowledge and of life, nonetheless have their value — and that not for us alone. A characterization of the Danish philosophers can teach us a great deal by way of orientation toward those questions, and it will often appear that our thinkers might very well have made their mark on a larger stage, had circumstances assigned them one. The heaven of thought is, like the physical heaven, accessible to all, not only to those born among a great people. This book will therefore be able to cast light on the philosophical problems themselves, and not merely serve to characterize Danish intellectual life as it expresses itself in the domain of thought.

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¹See my essay on Swedish and Danish philosophy in the collection *Norden* (1902), as well as my essay *Filosofien i Sverige* [Philosophy in Sweden] (*Det Letterstedtske Tidsskrift*, 1879). — On the philosophical movements abroad that come to influence Danish philosophy, fuller information will be found in my work *Den nyere Filosofis Historie* [The History of Modern Philosophy] by means of the index. — Biographies I do not as a rule give, chiefly because I can refer to the excellent articles by my colleague Professor Kroman in the *Biografisk Leksikon*.

I. Ludvig Holberg

Danish philosophy begins with the very founder of our literature. He is the first here at home to take an independent stand on the problems of thought, at the same time as he brings the ideas and attempted solutions that had arisen abroad into Danish intellectual life.

Holberg no doubt stands first and foremost for us as a poet, but it would be wrong to see him solely from this point of view and to interpret his moods amid the vicissitudes of his life merely in the light of the fate his poetic work met with. Inquiry held a central interest for him and filled an essential part of his life, from his young days to his advanced old age. He held, as does his Erasmus Montanus, that studies are an ornament in the days of good fortune and a consolation in those of misfortune. Nothing befell him so heavily that it was not made lighter by study — as he himself said. It is characteristic that a similar remark is attributed to Leibniz, who likewise had a many-sided interest in reading and inquiry. But Leibniz had a brighter and lighter view of life and of men than Holberg, whose heavy nature did not let him rest content with the crystal-clear prism into which Leibniz had ground his view of life. He could not be led by speculative considerations to overlook the disharmonies of life or to be reconciled with them. For Holberg the evil in the world was a hardship not so easily broken. Human life suffered in particular under a great opposition between appearance and reality. “The shadow is taken for the body” — this expression recurs again and again in Holberg, and he wrote his comedies, his *Niels Klim*, and his *Moralske Tanker* [Moral Reflections] in order to counteract this perpetual confusion. He does not wish to preach morality, but to tear illusions apart and awaken men to self-knowledge.

When he thus ascribes to himself an express moral purpose in all his works, this is to be understood only as an interpretation he afterwards placed upon his authorship. There was of course at work in him an involuntary urge to unfold his intellectual power in the fields of poetry, historical research, and thought, and only when in his old age he looked back on his rich and manifold activity did he find, in a moral aim, a somewhat artificial

and philistine explanation.² But his work of thought was a side of his activity that he looked back upon with particular pleasure. Just as he thought he could “say without scruple that he is almost the first Dane who, in place of meagre and confused chronicles, has given us tolerably well-ordered histories,” so too he prided himself on having “set the study of morals on its feet again, which right up to this time had lain as if buried here in the North.”

But Holberg was not merely a moral philosopher. He occupied himself with the new science and the new view of the world that had developed in the age of the Renaissance, and whose most conspicuous and at the same time most far-reaching results were the changed position of the Earth in the picture of the world and the unboundedness of the world. And besides this, his thought was taken up with the great oppositions of the world and of life, which culminated in the problem of evil — a problem that in Holberg’s very youth was being discussed by such great thinkers as Bayle and Leibniz.

His thought loved to set oppositions sharply against one another, so that the problem might spring forth all the more from the strong collision — the opposition, for example, between the infinite horizon that science had opened up and human life with its striving and its wishes; the oppositions within human nature; the conflict of good and evil. In treating questions of this kind he was fond of “paradoxical opinions,” by which he understood such as “with good reasons overturn the opinions that have gained citizenship.” It was not a bent for hair-splitting or for playing with ideas that guided him here: the paradoxes had to have “probability” — that is, to be really well-founded — and this they were when it was widened experience that led to them. He saw that when one places oneself on the broad ground of experience — when one bases one’s judgments on experience — one comes to doubt much that had hitherto stood as self-evident. It is no wonder that one arrives at fixed opinions when one holds to the given traditions and lets them determine what one experiences and how one interprets what one has experienced.

It is on this point above all that Holberg’s significance as a thinker lies — in the weight he places on as wide an experience as possible and on the problems that experience presents at any given time. Both these tendencies make a conclusive systematization difficult, if not impossible. When Holberg, in the preface to *Moralske Tanker*, speaks of completing his system,³ he surely meant thereby only a rounding-off or conclusion so far as his own person was concerned. Even the most open and acute thinker halts at

²Compare my essay on Holberg in *Mindre Arbejder* [Minor Works], Second Series, pp. 150–153.

³“In view of my age and infirmity, I regard myself as a man ready to set out on a journey, who must draw up his *Systema* before he takes his leave and sets off.”

a boundary, but he need not regard this boundary as the boundary of all thought and experience.

With this it agrees that when Holberg is to say to which philosophers he owes the most, he names John Locke, the chief representative of empiricist philosophy, and Pierre Bayle, the great critic and raiser of problems. On the whole he owes most to English and French intellectual life. Nowhere on his travels abroad did he feel so much at home as in Oxford and Paris. He rejoiced that he had come to study at the French and English academies, and he called England in particular “the true school of philosophy.”

When Holberg, after his travels, after the experience he had gathered, and after his thought had been sharpened by his persistent occupation with the problems of the age, attempted to philosophize in the Danish academic world, great difficulties arose for him from various quarters.

The Danish language was but little fashioned for more advanced thinking; it had narrow limits to its diffusion — and within those limits it was not respected by its own people. “My name,” says Holberg, “might perhaps have been tolerably well known abroad, had I not written in the Danish language, which is so confined that often in Denmark itself one must search for someone who understands it.” The greater gratitude must we feel toward the founder of our literature that he did not despise this language, but did what he could to cultivate it into an instrument for thought. Had he, for the sake of his fame, written in a foreign tongue, a Danish life of thought would not have developed. What he began was carried on by his successors, especially by Eilschow, Sneedorff, and Kraft.

But in this still little-developed language one could not express oneself so freely as in the other countries, especially in England. “Here in our North,” says Holberg, “we are plagued with sharp censorships, by which all gaiety and spirit are damped in a writer.” When a book is furnished with an “Imprimatur,” it is usually a sign that there is nothing to it. It was above all from the theological side that the censorship was prompted; Holberg noticed this especially with *Niels Klim*. “I took particular care that the clergy should not get occasion to array themselves in armour against me, since I know from experience that these people are the most implacable.” “It is only those adversaries I fear who clothe themselves in the armour of religion.” And in his last years he grew even more cautious: “I put my words and writings on screws more than before, since I have noticed that at one time they were being examined more closely.” — Holberg’s religious opinions were not orthodox. Of that there is no doubt, though it may be difficult to decide where earnestness leaves off in his utterances and where caution begins. People have exaggerated both the

earnestness and the caution — have found both more orthodoxy and more tactics in him than there are. He had his theology, which he held to be reasonable and consonant with his experience. It goes not much further than Rousseau's and Kant's, but he thought that, by right interpretation, it could be said to be contained in the biblical and dogmatic conceptions.

Most of the students (two-thirds) at the University of Copenhagen in Holberg's time studied theology, and the scholastic philosophy still cultivated here at home was regarded as an important means of guarding the true doctrine. By formal logic thought was to be trained in distinctions and syllogisms so as to be able to set dogmatics in system. In *Erasmus Montanus* Holberg presents a young dialectical fencer of the kind that the constant disputation exercises were bound to produce. His formal virtuosity drives him to undertake to prove whatsoever it may be. "That is why," says Erasmus Montanus, "I have studied, and that is why I have racked my brains, so that I can say what I will and defend it before the whole world." In the scenes where Erasmus disputes with the folk on the Hill, however, Holberg does not let him use the logic that was taught at the university. Erasmus is fond of proceeding by affirmative syllogisms in the second figure,⁴ which scholasticism knew very well to be invalid. But Holberg employs such sophisms as Aristophanes and Plato had already ascribed to their opponents. Instead of showing the uselessness of formal quibbling, he has achieved a comic effect through the way in which the respect that the folk on the Hill nonetheless had for Copenhagen learning caused sheer nonsense to stand as proven truth.

Among the subjects to which logical acuteness is applied, Erasmus names first and foremost the theological ones — for example, the question whether the angels were created before men. But such questions are named too as whether the Earth is round or oval, and concerning the distance and size of the sun and stars; and it is on a question of this latter kind that Erasmus is brought down by the home-grown Inquisition. Now it is characteristic that questions of this latter kind interested Holberg himself in a high degree and led him to some of his boldest thoughts, as will be shown in what follows. Here he had "the Hill" and "the learned men of the Hill" against himself, and he would have come into a conflict similar to that of Erasmus Montanus, had he here openly drawn the consequences. But in the comedy his main concern was to set useful studies over against mere sword-play, and so he was ruthless enough to let Erasmus fall precisely where he was in the right. The Lieutenant in the fifth act, the play's moralist, has, like Holberg, chiefly studied "Latin authors, natural law, and moral matters," which Montanus

⁴A is B and C is B, therefore A is C! Nille cannot fly, a stone cannot fly, therefore Nille is a stone!

regards as trifling. The moral of the play is expressed in the Lieutenant's words: "The first commandment in philosophy is to know oneself. . . The more one does, the more there seems to remain to learn. But you make philosophy into an art of fencing."

Instead of the subtleties or the broodings over the nature of God and the angels that were then called metaphysics, Holberg wished to turn to subjects that could yield a positive return for philosophizing. Instead of countless uncertain things he wanted a few certain ones. — Let us then bring forward the chief questions that especially occupied Holberg's thought.

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Often in his later years Holberg declares that moral philosophy is his real study. The chief work here is *Moralske Tanker* (1744). It is not a systematic book, but a series of little essays that occasionally stray into less scientific subjects, for there is talk not only of poetry and of studies, but also of the reasons why the author has not married, and of the interesting question whether a bad stomach is as bad as a bad wife. But the main thought, to which he returns again and again, is that there exists a morality founded on the light of nature. In his *Epistler* [Epistles] too, the other chief source of his philosophy, he maintains this proposition. "Natural morals are one study, theological morals another. When one undertakes to write of the former, it is required that one found the doctrine on the light of nature." But natural morality is not, as was claimed, "a heathen morality." "Christ's morality" too is founded on the light of nature; the difference is merely that the same "morality" is carried out in greater perfection.

Holberg's ethics is religious in so far as he connects it with "natural religion." But he will have morality placed before the special dogmas and mysteries. "One must, through Christ's morality and a sound philosophy, lay the foundation before the dogmas and mysteries of Christianity are taught." "Children must be made into human beings before they become Christians." A human confirmation must precede the Christian one; for if a person learns theology before he learns to become a human being, he never becomes a human being. "One begins by crying: Believe! before one shows what one ought to believe and not to believe. That is to go to work like that judge who began with the execution and afterwards had the case examined." One ought to impart to men a critical faculty, that they may not take the shadow for the body.

For Holberg the foundation of the Reformation was "the Christian freedom to search before one believes." "It is in a person's power to search, but not to believe." Error after careful examination is more excusable than orthodoxy without preceding inquiry. Strife is better than brutal concord. Holberg himself would rather read heretics than

the orthodox, because the latter answer more with abuse than with reasons. And it was his conviction that one had to give up the outworks of the doctrine of faith in order to defend the main fortress the better. For his own part he was willing to subscribe to all the fundamental articles of faith found in the Confession; yet he would rather reduce than increase their number, for there is need of nowhere near so many articles of faith as are commonly alleged to be quite necessary. — Unfortunately Holberg does not say which ones he would strike out.

He will not have inquiry brought to a halt by one's taking refuge in "God's motives and reserved causes" or "the imperfection of reason and God's inscrutable ways." That is a sign of laziness. Such an appeal is permissible only when one has striven with all one's might to find out the cause and has sought to reconcile the difficulties that arise with reason.

Nevertheless, as already indicated, there is in Holberg's moral catechism (*Epistle 46*) both a religious and a rational element. It is founded on natural religion. The first three articles treat of God and immortality. The fourth article demands that no doctrine be accepted before it is made demonstrable; for otherwise one may fall into false belief as readily as into true, and reason, God's most excellent gift, would be of no use. The fifth article demands the rejection of all doctrines that conflict with God's holy attributes, and the sixth runs thus: Hate and persecute no one who against his will goes astray in his faith!

Of the two elements the rational lies deepest, and logically the fourth article ought to have been placed before the three preceding ones. Very clear is a statement from *Moralske Tanker* that the right method would be to explain to the young the chief commandments of nature, to set forth what fairness, justice, and goodness are — that they are virtues in God's creatures and *therefore* must consistently be attributes of the Godhead itself. — Thus the attributes ascribed to God must first be known from the human world. It is then a circular inference when one derives morality from theology, grounding human justice by the divine. The ethical, according to Holberg, takes priority over the religious; the latter is understood by means of the former, before the reverse can become the case.

The "light of nature" Holberg finds revealed in certain principles that for him are immediately evident. "The great commandment of nature": Do not to others what you would not have them do to you! — will, he thinks, be granted by everyone who hears it explained — even though Locke is right that it cannot be said to be innate. It is as clear as that a thing cannot at one and the same time be and not be. — Morality thus has its own source, even though it stands in close connection with natural religion. Whether that

principle is really self-evident is another question. The problem of how we come to set up the principles on which all ethical demonstration rests, Holberg does not enter into.

As regards the individual qualities and actions, Holberg impresses upon us that all perfection depends on a definite limitation: "All virtue consists in mediocrity, and as soon as it passes beyond the bounds, it is metamorphosed into vice." "The Danish proverb, Fear God and follow the highway! is quite well founded; for those who are always looking for byways and wish to shorten the roads most often arrive last. And it is of such crafty wayfarers that people here in this country say that they go by Per Gante's shortcut." — Unfortunately there is perhaps something Danish in these rules. But one would gravely misunderstand Holberg if one supposed that he recommends a middle-of-the-road morality. He does so as little as Aristotle did in his doctrine of virtue as the right mean.⁵ What is too much or too little is determined by the individual's nature and may differ from individual to individual. What for one is a byway may be a highway for another. It was not Holberg's meaning to exclude new roads. His comparisons and examples show clearly what he means. In case of sickness one patient is to have one pill, another two or three. A choleric man must be judged otherwise than one born with a "temperate complexion." One who has no gall cannot be praised for coolness of temper. To ride on a tame ass is no merit, but to govern a wild and mettlesome horse deserves applause and clapping of hands. In the chastisement of misdeeds the punishment ought to be fitted to the malefactor's constitution; a misdeed may be equally great and yet not equally punishable in different persons.

It is thus an individualization of morality that Holberg demands. In ethical evaluations and demands, account is to be taken of the inner personal conditions of individuals, and all cannot be cut by one measure. Holberg does not, it is true, go deeply into the problem that here comes to light, namely how far regard for the individual dispositions of particular persons can be reconciled with the demands that the existence of society makes. But the problem of the individual here steps forth for the first time in Danish thought. — On closer examination it will prove to be bound up with the question of the demonstrability and practicability of ethical principles.⁶

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Holberg not only felt an urge to think about ethical questions. He is at the same time the first here at home to have brooded over the influence that the new conception of

⁵See on this my *Etik* [Ethics] XI, 9 (cf. IV, 2). (Third edition, p. 221 f.; p. 89).

⁶Compare my essay on the Law of Relation in Ethics (*Etiske Undersøgelser* [Ethical Investigations], 1891, pp. 42–83).

the world — founded by Copernicus, Galileo, Descartes, and Newton — was bound to have on one's very view of life. He emphasizes here the enlargement that the picture of the world has received through the new discoveries and ways of seeing. The new astronomy has widened our conceptions and given us a greater idea of God. More than ever, speculations about God now stand as unreasonable. He declares himself in agreement with the Greek Simonides that the more one thinks about such questions, the more difficult they become. It is of no use to say, with "common theology," that Simonides speaks out of heathen blindness, but that revelation has brought enlightenment; for the figurative expressions that the Bible predominantly uses give no proper concept, indeed lead to "coarse and carnal conceptions." Holberg finds that those versed in nature have higher thoughts of the divine Being than the common crowd, indeed than many of the clergy themselves, in that they do not, like the latter, make attempts to express the incomprehensible. The deeper we enter into the investigation of what eternity, infinity, omniscience, omnipresence ("all-being"), and omnipotence are, the more we drown in them and see ever less.

According to the new picture of the world, moreover, the Earth stands as a grain of sand over against the infinite universe; it is no longer the centre of the world, and even the sun about which it revolves is only one star among countless other stars. Men are like worms that creep about on a little hillock and yet imagine that everything exists for their sake. From this side too it appears how hopeless metaphysical and theological speculations are.

In the world of natural science and of philosophy there still stood, in Holberg's time, the dispute between Descartes's and Newton's teachings concerning the motions of the heavenly bodies and the laws underlying them. Descartes assumed that the universe consisted of systems, each of which was in whirling motion. The globes belonging to the same vortex were driven round by the motion of the surrounding mass. That the globes did not, by virtue of the law of inertia, fly off into the universe away from the centre of their system was explained by the fact that the surrounding mass, in which they as it were swam, continually carried them round the centre. Newton rejected this vortex theory and explained the globes' remaining in their orbits by gravity or attraction, which constantly counteracted the tendency to fly off in a straight line. Holberg seems to have been much taken up with this discussion. "According to the cursory knowledge he has of it," he prefers to hold to the Cartesian conception, because it appears to him simple and intuitible, whereas Newton appears to him to appeal to a mysterious force when he speaks of attraction.

But if the universe consists of many worlds in constant whirling motion, how does this square with the biblical account of the creation of the world? This point had in Holberg's younger days caused him much doubt and unease. He settled the matter for himself, however, in this way: that the Mosaic creation-story tells only of the coming-into-being of the vortex-system to which the Earth belongs. There is, after all, nothing said about its having been the first or the only world that was created! Perhaps there takes place a perpetual arising and passing-away of worlds!

It is the boldest thought Holberg hints at. And with this thought there is given a great background for Holberg's view of the world, which his own caution and the pettiness of the age prevented him from bringing forth more definitely, but which is nonetheless felt in the freedom of spirit that his thought on the whole bears witness to. His conceptions of the decisive questions unfolded under the influence of a wide horizon, which would have come forth more clearly had he not himself, too much in the less happy sense of the words, "feared God and followed the highway."

Yet one point still remains as that in which Holberg deviated in the most decisive way from the orthodox way of thinking — namely his position on the problem of evil, a problem that shortly before his appearance had been discussed by Bayle and Leibniz. Pierre Bayle had maintained the impossibility of explaining the origin of evil if one started from the conception of an all-good and almighty God as the author of all things — and had declared that the only consistent assumption, when one took one's stand on the standpoint of natural reason with revelation left aside, was the presupposition of two original principles, a good and an evil, in constant strife and struggle, as the Manichaeans had taught. Holberg, however, could as little accept this dualistic conception as he could follow Leibniz in his optimistic speculations. But one of his friends, whom he designates by B. S. (it is supposed to be Rector Bernhard Schnabel in Roskilde), had shown him a way out: if God from the beginning stands over against a chaotic matter that is not perfectly receptive to the forms he wishes to impress upon it, but offers a certain resistance, then it is understood that not only the perfect exists, but also the imperfect. One then avoids the Manichaean assumption of two active principles, a good and an evil God, and holds fast to the belief in a good God whose carrying-out of his intentions is hampered by a recalcitrant matter. Such a view (of a kind similar to that in which Rousseau and Voltaire, and later Stuart Mill and William James, ended up) would — Holberg thinks — have disarmed Bayle, had revelation not taught a creation out of nothing. On this point his accommodation and apparent submission to Church doctrine is quite plain. With his teaching about the origin of our world-system as the successor of an earlier one, the

solution of the problem of evil here indicated would have fitted excellently.

For the rest, Holberg has yet another argument against Bayle. The different beings must be measured by different measures. A human being's perfection is other than a fly's and than an angel's; every being is perfect in its kind. This line of thought accords well with Holberg's individualizing of ethics, and it presupposes that the measure is taken from the very nature of the individual beings, each for itself. It raises a problem similar to the individualization of ethics, and in sharper form.

Here, as at several other points, Holberg has developed his thoughts neither fully nor consistently. But he has done a foundational work and made free movement of thought possible here at home. For the first time, great problems were discussed in his writings in Danish and in a Danish spirit.

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2. Sneedorff and the Wolffians

Holberg's figure fills so much of Danish intellectual life in the eighteenth century that there seems to be an empty space after him. In independent thinking, no one at the close of the century came near him. But he had awakened a desire to think and had shown the possibility of using the Danish language for it. Among the best of the younger men there stirred a sense of shame that there did not yet exist a Danish scientific literature, while other European peoples had long since begun to use their mother tongue in science.

The one who, as a thinker, worked most nearly in Holberg's spirit was Jens Schiønderup Sneedorff. Like Holberg he was influenced by English and French literature. Shaftesbury and Montesquieu in particular exerted an influence on him. He was born in 1724 and studied at Göttingen, whose university was visited by many foreigners and where philosophy, political science, and natural science flourished. Later he served (1751–1761) as professor of law and political science at the newly founded Academy at Sorø, which in its brief flowering became the cradle of Danish scientific literature. He died as early as 1764.

Sneedorff praises Holberg's great services to our language and our literature. "But we should not be worthy of having such a fellow citizen if, out of laziness or baseness, we were to believe that there was nothing for us to do." The struggle for the mother tongue and for true, natural thinking goes hand in hand in Sneedorff. Away with barbarous technical terms and academic sword-play — with dead memory and dead abstraction!

According to the historians of language, the foundation of the more modern Danish language was laid by Sneedorff and his contemporaries. —

Sneedorff's thought concerns partly matters of law and the state, partly general philosophical points of view.

In the first respect the chief work is *Den borgerlige Regering* [Civil Government] (1757). The weight is here laid on the principle that a good government must follow principles that build on experience and accord with the nature of the people; only such a government can win the people's trust. Written laws, not least constitutions, are unnecessary — indeed they may be harmful on account of their unalterability, which

hinders the constant interplay with experience. The Danish absolute monarchy was in Sneedorff's eyes the only absolute monarchy that was grounded on the people's trust, and he protests therefore against its being called despotism. — But in order that experiences may be made, and that the nature of the people may reveal itself, public opinion must unfold freely, and to this again belong enlightenment as well as freedom in all civil relations for all estates, not least for the hitherto so neglected peasantry. Freedom makes men active and reasonable, and without freedom there is no honour! —

Absolute monarchy is here recognized because it is enlightened and popular, no longer because it is by the grace of God. A turn in thought and in justification that was bound to have far-reaching consequences!

Sneedorff was one of those who, in the domain of general ideas, worked to prepare the great agrarian reforms in Denmark at the close of the eighteenth century. Whereas Holberg had still held that the peasant must be kept to work by compulsory laws, Sneedorff and those of like mind maintained that both regard for personal freedom and for the common good — considerations that at bottom coincide — demanded changes in the peasants' condition.⁷

Sneedorff's general philosophical standpoint already reveals itself in his doctrine of law and the state, but he develops it more closely, partly in polemical forms, in his periodical *Den patriotiske Tilskuer* [The Patriotic Spectator] (especially in the first volume, 1761).

Where it is a matter of experience and the description of experience, or where it is a matter of finding expression for the life of feeling, there, according to Sneedorff, one cannot apply strict definitions and methods of proof. What essentially matters is to procure as full a content as possible, and a logical or mathematical formulation would here only have a narrowing effect — indeed, at bottom, rest on an illusion. On the ground of experience we reach only probabilities ("likelihoods"), not necessities. And we must be cautious about finding contradictions, for these may fall away with widened experience, which can teach us that there are far more possibilities than we imagined.

It is characteristic that Sneedorff, in his discussion of the relation of experience to logical contradictions, emphasizes the opposite side from the one on which Holberg dwelt. Holberg laid weight on the point that the greater the experience we gain, the more contradictions and difficulties we shall find. It was his business to find and pose

⁷Compare E. Holm: *Om det Syn paa Kongemagt, Folk og borgerlig Frihed, der udviklede sig i den dansk-norske Stat i Midten af det attende Aarhundrede* [On the View of Royal Power, People, and Civil Liberty that Developed in the Dano-Norwegian State in the Middle of the Eighteenth Century] (University Programme, 1883), pp. 107–114.

problems. Sneedorff dwells especially on the working of widened experience to make the provisionally found contradictions fall away. This is bound up with the brighter tone that lies over his philosophizing, and with his hope in progress, but also with a weakening in the sense for the sharpness of problems — of the ever-recurring problems.

But Sneedorff is not dogmatic. Just as he has a clear eye for the hypothetical character of the propositions we draw from experience — the chief source of our knowledge — so too he has an eye for the role that analogy plays in the border-region of thought, indeed already when we wish to infer what goes on in the inner life of other beings. And he maintains that only individual things are real, while species and generic designations are due to our thinking. There is expressed in this last proposition a sense for the individual, which we have already met with in Holberg and shall find again in later Danish thinkers (Treschow, A. S. Ørsted, Kierkegaard). Sneedorff protests against philosophy's being metaphysics and logic alone. The study of the mind's operations and movements demands fineness and loftiness of thought no less than pure metaphysics, and jurisprudence and aesthetics now claim their right, after theology, philology, mathematics, and metaphysics have so long had the say.

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Holberg and Sneedorff belong to the kind of thinkers who strive to build on experience, with full awareness that by this path no absolute conclusion can be reached. They take a stand against the thinking that starts from certain dogmatically established principles, from which one then proceeds by strict inferences. Experience here receives a subordinate significance. For a large part, Sneedorff's expositions are directed against Jens Kraft (1720–1765), professor of mathematics at Sorø and author of a whole series of philosophical textbooks. Kraft had, in his *Kritiske Breve til Videnskabernes Fremvæxt og Smagens Forbedring* [Critical Letters on the Growth of the Sciences and the Improvement of Taste] (1761), defended the mathematical (deductive) method in science. He emphasized the indispensability of abstract thinking and of mathematics if knowledge is to be thorough and if it is to be applied in practice, and he fears that the preponderance of “the fine sciences” will lead to indolence and superficial cleverness. On Sneedorff's emphasizing of the method of experience, however, he does not enter.

Some years before (1751–1753), Kraft had published a systematic presentation of metaphysics after the method of the German philosopher Wolff. By metaphysics he understands “the doctrine of the first and most necessary fundamental teachings needed for human knowledge.” The first part is ontology, the doctrine of the most universal truths, which can be reduced to two: that the self-contradictory is impossible, and that

everything has its cause. The second part is cosmology, the doctrine “of the forces and primary physical properties of natural things,” the key to physics. Here he parts from Wolff by adopting Newton’s hypothesis and rejecting Descartes’s; the book thereby marks a turning point in Danish science. The third part is psychology. Here Wolff distinguished between rational (speculative) and experimental (empirical) psychology. Kraft fuses the two together, remarking: “Among all the theoretical discoveries about the soul I have found but few of importance, and I have therefore held that one might with propriety and right introduce them together with the experimental in a single work.” Here, then, Kraft himself wished to let experience come into its own. The fourth and last part is “the natural doctrine of God, or natural theology.” Here God’s existence is proved partly by the argument that there must be a first beginning to the changes in the world, since otherwise these would not have their sufficient ground, and the question of the origin would otherwise ever recur without being answered; partly by the argument that it lies in the concept of God as the infinite and perfect Being that he must exist, since he has his ground in himself and is not dependent on anything else that could exclude his existence.

Kraft’s work is the only completed system written in Danish. Apart from the individual points singled out, it rests entirely on Wolff’s philosophy, the first German system. Chr. Wolff was a disciple of Leibniz, and his philosophy is at once a popularization and a systematization of the master’s thoughts. He supplanted the old scholasticism at the German universities, just as Descartes had supplanted it in France and Holland, and Locke in England. But his theological colleagues at Halle feared the consequences of the new philosophy, partly because it so zealously maintained “the principle of sufficient reason,” which seemed to them to lead to fatalism, partly because it taught the possibility of a purely human morality. In Denmark too it was ill regarded while Pietism held sway. One of the first Danes to be influenced by it, Henrik Stampe, is said for that reason to have lodged “half incognito, at least as regards court chaplain Bluhme,” in Wolff’s house. Wolffianism was first introduced at the University of Copenhagen by jurists (Stampe, Kofod Anker) and theologians (Gunnerus). But the first purely philosophical writer here at home of this tendency was Frederik Christian Eilschow (1725–1750).

Just as Wolff in Germany created a philosophical terminology to replace the Latin one, and for the most part did so, so too it was one of Eilschow’s endeavours to replace the many foreign scientific words with Danish ones, and these had then first to be coined. Eilschow has often been felicitous in his proposals in this respect. Words such as *Enkelthed* (singularity), *Sandsynlighed* (probability), *Sædelighed* (morality), *Personlighed*

(personality), *Selvbevidsthed* (self-consciousness), *Sindsbevægelse* (emotion), and *Overflade* (surface) are due to him. He maintains that the sciences ought to be presented in the people's own language. Against those who held that there was no reason to abandon Latin, since practical people had no time for reading of a scientific kind anyway, he appeals to his own experience. There are many who, without belonging to the learned, buy and read scientific books whose language they understand; many hours, indeed whole nights, they spend absorbed in them.⁸

Eilschow praises the English because they lay such great weight on experience, and on account of the many profound thoughts that come from England. But he attaches himself predominantly to Wolff, whose philosophy he wishes to make more accessible, also to ladies,⁹ and whose work he also wishes to continue.¹⁰ Wolff had, indeed, set metaphysics in system, dividing it into fundamental doctrine (ontology), the doctrine of the world (cosmology), the doctrine of the soul (psychology), and natural theology. Eilschow did not himself treat all these subjects; such a treatment was, as already mentioned, given by Kraft some years later. It is natural theology that Eilschow especially occupies himself with. It is from the concept of possibility that Eilschow will conduct his proof of God's existence. No finite thing's possibility has its ground in itself; but all possibilities have their ultimate ground in God's possibility — and this has its ground in itself, just as all numbers presuppose the number one. This is, however, not to be understood as though the possibilities of things were due to God's will. They stand independently of his will in his eternal thought; only their realization is due to the will. Against the eternal possibilities the will can do nothing — the divine will as little as the human.

Now the source of evil — of pain and of sin — lies in the limitation to which everything finite as such is subject, and which follows from the fact that finite beings stand in connection with one another. This connection, which in itself is a good, brings with it barriers and therewith the possibility of imperfection. Evil cannot then be charged to God's account, since he has as little created the possibilities as he has created his own understanding.¹¹

As little as Leibniz and Wolff has Eilschow answered the objection that Bayle raised and that Holberg repeated: why, then, has God created a world of which he knew that it contained the possibility of pain and sin, a possibility that neither divine nor human

⁸Eilschow: *Cogitationes de scientiis vernacula lingua docendis*, Hafniæ 1747, p. 7.

⁹*Forsøg til en Fruentimmerphilosophie* [Attempt at a Philosophy for Ladies]. Copenhagen 1749.

¹⁰*Philosophiske Breve over adskillige nyttige og vigtige Ting* [Philosophical Letters on Various Useful and Important Things]. Copenhagen 1748.

¹¹*Philosophiske Breve*, p. 150. — A similar line of thought is found in Jens Kraft's *Naturlige Theologie*, pp. 13–16. — Eilschow states, however, that we cannot infer from the imperfections found in one part of the world to the imperfection of the whole.

will could annul? Holberg is more consistent than Eilschow. Understanding and will, possibility and actuality, are here in such a degree at war with one another that they must really belong to two different beings. The God who is willing but not able is not almighty; he has a barrier — whether one now, with Holberg, seeks it in an eternal matter, or, with the Manichaeans, in an eternal evil being, an Ahriman. — Eilschow lacks Holberg's sense for the seriousness of problems.¹²

On the question of the relation between reason and revelation, Eilschow likewise makes use of the distinction between possibility and actuality. God can reveal something that one cannot derive from reason and from the possibilities it establishes; but he cannot reveal anything that overthrows natural knowledge, contradicts the clearest reports of the senses, and upsets all that on which the certainty of all truths rests.

Just as Sneedorff recognized absolute monarchy because it worked in the service of enlightenment and of the popular cause, and not because it sprang from the grace of God, so Eilschow and the other Wolffians recognized revelation in the confidence that it does not contradict reason and the eternal possibilities. The question was bound to become — and did become — on which side the wrong lies when a contradiction actually shows itself. There came the time, toward the close of the century, when men were in no doubt that a contradiction was present, nor in doubt on which side the wrong lay.

For the time being, Eilschow was sure that he had in hand the means to refute the freethinkers, that is, those who deny the divine providence.¹³ They sin against metaphysics and are refuted by means of the aforementioned doctrine of the possibilities and their ultimate ground. Without metaphysics one easily goes astray, precisely in such questions as the origin of evil and providence. Yet Eilschow thinks that the freethinkers really merely wish for freedom to sin, and that they deny the truth in order to escape obeying it. There are, to be sure, some — such as Spinoza — who have led a fine life; but that is inconsistent, since they expect no reward or punishment after death. —

More kindly disposed than toward the freethinkers is Eilschow toward the animals. He is one of the first philosophers of the modern age to maintain that we have duties toward animals. In order for one to have a duty toward a being, it is not necessary that it have reason, provided only that it has the capacity to suffer. There exists a community between them and us, in that we take their service and in return have duties toward them. —

¹²A purely philosophical standpoint on the problem of evil is given in my *Religionsfilosofi* [Philosophy of Religion], §§ 88–89, and my *Etik* [Ethics], chap. VI.

¹³The word freethinker comes from England (free-thinker) and first occurs around the year 1700, used of and by men such as Toland and Collins. Earlier, from the sixteenth century on, designations such as deists and naturalists were used in France.

Wolff's systematic philosophy held sway at the university until into the new century. Its last representative was Børge Riisbrigh (born 1731, died 1809), who was professor of philosophy from 1767 to 1803. His teaching is praised for its formal clarity, but he was not very productive. The most considerable work from his hand is a treatise (from 1802–03) on Kant's philosophy, a work that does him honour and that will be discussed later on.

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3. Danish Kantians and Their Opponents

The Wolffian system was in Germany supplanted by one of the most profound works of thought that the history of philosophy knows — by Kant's critical philosophy. Kant had been aroused by Hume's critique of the causal principle, the principle on which all natural science and all speculative philosophy and theology built. At the same time Newton's mathematically developed natural science stood before him as the ideal of scientific knowledge. When he now asked how such science was possible despite Hume's demonstration that the causal principle was neither self-evident nor demonstrable, he found the solution in this: that there are certain forms with which the human mind, according to its nature, constantly works, and of which it must therefore make use when it is to establish what has objective validity — what is truth and reality. Thereby it became at once possible to acknowledge science in its independence and to see its limits; these must lie where the human mind's forms of intuition and thought no longer find any given material to be applied to. Science cannot therefore go further than the possibility of experience goes. When this possibility fails, a person can — and must — have a personal faith to support his holding fast to the command of conscience; but a speculative theology is impossible.

The law of conscience was, according to Kant, a pure law of reason: just as the human mind in its science strives to bring observations under the forms and laws of intuition and understanding — under the forms of space and time, of the concept of magnitude and the concept of cause — so it can convince itself of the morality of an action only when it can show that the action can be acknowledged on the basis of a universal law valid for all; the maxim I follow in my action must be such that everyone in my place could follow it.

As Kant, from developed science, seeks back to the innermost nature of thought itself at work, so on the ethical-religious domain he sought back to the self-legislation of conscience. From the principles he thus gained, he judged the speculative systems

and the theological dogmas. His great sense for the original forces led him further, on the aesthetic domain, to point to genius as the involuntarily welling source of art. In thought, in conscience, and in genius there expresses itself, for Kant, one and the same fundamental force in different forms. By this great idea Kant at once forms the conclusion of the eighteenth century's intellectual labour and points far beyond its horizon.

It was a young, promising scholar who especially aroused attention for Kant's philosophy in Denmark. In the spring of 1793 Christian Hornemann (born 1769) delivered lectures on Kant's critique of reason. They were cut short by the author's death the same year, and the great hopes that had been placed in him fell to the ground. With great enthusiasm he had taken Kant's principal ideas into himself, and a period of study with Reinhold at Jena had developed his philosophical interest. In his lectures (which are printed in his *Efterladte Skrifter* [Posthumous Writings], 1795) he gave a clear account of the relation of the critical philosophy to earlier conceptions and then began to go through Kant's principal work; but he got no further than the end of the doctrine of space and time. — Hornemann's main task seems to have been to show how the religious problem would present itself under the presupposition of the new conception.

The purely theoretical side of Kant's philosophy was but little brought forward here at home, and just as little the aesthetic. It was the moral- and religious-philosophical side that was especially attended to. The most considerable champion of Kant's ethics and doctrine of right was the man who later became Denmark's greatest jurist, Anders Sandøe Ørsted (born 1778); in 1798 he won the university's gold medal for a prize essay *Om Sammenhængen mellem Dyds- og Retslærens Princip* [On the Connection between the Principle of the Doctrine of Virtue and that of the Doctrine of Right], an excellent presentation for its time of Kant's ethics and philosophy of right, and an account of the discussions to which this gave rise among contemporaries, both abroad and here at home. In the standing dispute between the "Bible party" (the Palaeologists) and the "Reason party" (the Neologists) — the first represented by Bishop Balle, the second by Horrebow (editor of the periodical *Jesus og Fornuften* [Jesus and Reason]) — Ørsted took part with a longer essay (in *Philosophisk Repertorium*, 1797–1798), directed against Horrebow's popular half-philosophy. From a standpoint similar to Lessing's in *Erziehung des Menschengeschlechts* and Fichte's in *Kritik aller Offenbarung*, he points beyond the two contending parties. — Ørsted did not — as we shall see in a later connection — remain at the strictly Kantian standpoint he had taken in these essays. But admiration and gratitude toward his great teacher followed him all his life, and in his advanced old age he expressed it in a beautiful way.

It was, as Ørsted remarks in his autobiography,¹⁴ not so much the young theologians as the young jurists who occupied themselves with philosophy. And in the questions that occupied the last decade of the eighteenth century, the vigorous and free spirit that characterizes Kant's and Fichte's ethical and legal-philosophical views could have worked extraordinarily fruitfully. But there did not arise here, as in Germany, a series of independent and energetic thinkers and reformers such as those to whom the great reforms in Prussia after 1806 were due. The "Königsberg idealism," to which, according to Gneist, Prussia's restoration was for so large a part due, set no lasting effects in the life of the people here at home, and was early superseded by the more passive and dreaming tendency of Romanticism. This came partly from external political circumstances; partly, too, no doubt, from the fact that twelve years before the close of the century we had carried through one of the greatest reforms our country's history knows — a reform in which, moreover, as touched on in its place, philosophical ideas had also played a part. Besides Ørsted, whose philosophical and juridical studies in youth belonged to the preparation for his long activity as judge and legislator, one must nevertheless name a Kantian whose writings, by their clarity and energy, stand far above most of what was produced here at home in the public discussion that overflowed all its banks in the last decade of the eighteenth century, before the strict press regulation of 1799 stopped the free discussion of public affairs. The clergyman Michael Gottlieb Birckner (born 1756, died 1798) maintained, in his work *Om Trykkefriheden og dens Love* [On Freedom of the Press and Its Laws] (1797), that even in an absolute monarchy complete freedom of the press may very well prevail. — It was the ideal of enlightened absolutism — free discussion of all thoughts, and yet absolute obedience in all actions — that was here carried through to its uttermost consequence. Kant himself had, moreover, in his remarkable little essay *Was ist Aufklärung?* (1784), stated that only an enlightened autocrat, not a free state, dared say: Reason as much as you will — but obey! But it was then also Kant's opinion that such an autocrat the world had had only in Friedrich II of Prussia. Birckner's Kantianism had led him to continue a line of thought in which Sneedorff and his generation had already moved. In other domains too Birckner appears as a pronounced Kantian. Even more strongly than Kant, and without the sense for

¹⁴*Af mit Livs og min Tids Historie* [From the History of My Life and My Times], I (1851), p. 22. — A rather remarkable and independent position toward Kant's ethics was taken by the then professor of moral philosophy Anders Gamborg, who, following Hutcheson and Adam Smith, maintained a morality independent of religion and springing from love of humanity. In his first work (*Forskel mellem Dyd og gode Handlinger* [The Difference between Virtue and Good Actions], 1783) he does not yet know Kant's writings. In a later work (*Jesu Moral* [The Morality of Jesus], 1799) he declares that he is neither a eudaemonist nor a Kantian; yet he is glad that in his insistence on the unconditional character of the duty of truthfulness he agrees with Kant, though their grounds differ.

the sublime that marks the master's presentation, he asserts the sole right of reason in the ethical life. All feeling — with the exception of the pure feeling of respect that the moral law inspires — was for him really self-love. Even love of fatherland and love of humanity he would therefore not acknowledge as the proper ethical motives; they cannot be required and commanded, but must develop involuntarily, and it is not the immediate respect for the right that makes itself known in them, but the individual's personal captivation.¹⁵ —

Among the Danish Kantians, Baggesen must also be named. In him it was not the strict, rational side of Kant's philosophy that aroused interest, but precisely that character of sublimity which Kant's thoughts can present, especially when they move on the borderlines of experience. Kant satisfied for a time the young poet's rapturous searching, though he admitted that the purely theoretical enthusiasm was foreign to him. He philosophized, as he himself says in a letter to Reinhold,¹⁶ out of ethical and religious interest, and his work of thought really always aimed at procuring symbols for what moved in his feeling and his imagination. Philosophy was for him "Gedankenspiel" [a play of thoughts]: "Since I do not work in philosophy and on philosophy, my philosophizing — whether it consist in the reading of philosophical works or in conversation with philosophical friends — is only play, but the dearest of all plays."¹⁷ Poetry and philosophy strove over this strange spirit. And he stood not only on the border between two domains of the spirit, but also on the border between two centuries. We shall meet him later in the remarkable collision with Grundtvig, which promised so much but came to so little, because in Baggesen the play with symbols gained the upper hand over the seriousness of thought.

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¹⁵See his essays *Om Kierlighed til Fædrelandet* [On Love of the Fatherland] and *Om Christendommens højeste Moralprincip* [On the Highest Moral Principle of Christianity] (*Efterladte Skrifter* [Posthumous Writings], ed. A. S. Ørsted, Copenhagen 1800). — On the ethical and psychological misunderstandings in Kant's and Birckner's conception, see my *Etik* [Ethics] XII, 1.

¹⁶*Aus Jens Baggesens Briefwechsel mit Reinhold und Jacobi*, I, p. 6.

¹⁷*Op. cit.*, II, p. 56. — It is of interest to hear Reinhold's judgment of Baggesen, made to a third party: "Sein darstellender Genius ist sein Plagegeist. In den Augenblicken, wo er ihn in Ruhe lässt, ist Baggesen im Denken Philosoph und im Handeln verständiger Mann von der ersten Grösse — aber das sind auch nur Augenblicke — sonst ist er Engel oder Teufel, und befindet sich im Himmel oder in der Hölle — leider! öfters da als dort. Als Korrespondent (wenn er schreibt) und als auf einige Tage besuchender Gast hat er wohl Niemanden über sich." [His representative genius is his tormenting spirit. In the moments when it leaves him in peace, Baggesen is in thought a philosopher and in action a sensible man of the first rank — but those too are only moments — otherwise he is angel or devil, and finds himself in heaven or in hell — alas, more often there than here. As a correspondent (when he writes) and as a guest visiting for a few days he has, I think, no one above him.] Reinhold to Erhard, 2 Aug. 1796. (*Denkwürdigkeiten des Philosophen und Arztes Erhard*, ed. Varnhagen von Ense, 1830, p. 426).

Kantianism was met with no small resistance here at home from various sides, not least from the side of self-satisfied “Enlightenment.” And literary spokesmen such as Rahbek were vexed at the young Kantians’ arrogance and the new technical terms they threw about. “Enlightenment” was, moreover, agreed with Orthodoxy that it could not be so difficult as Kant thought to get the riddles of existence solved. Why all the many preparations, when one had one’s Bible and one’s catechism or one’s “sound common sense” to resort to?

But the new tendency of thought also found really philosophical opponents, and some of these have even with clarity pointed out defects and unsolved questions in the critical philosophy. Tyge Rothe and Johannes Boye collided with criticism in the course of their work at developing their own ideas, while Riisbrigh, Niels Schow, and Treschow directly examined its foundation and range.

Tyge Rothe’s (born 1731, died 1795) authorship falls into two periods, a historical-political and a philosophical. To the first period belong his writings on the influence of Christianity on the condition of the peoples in Europe and on the history of the North, which gave him occasion to work for the emancipation of the peasantry. To the second period belongs his chief philosophical work *Philosophies Ideer til Kundskab om vor Art og til Glæde over den* [Philosophy’s Ideas toward Knowledge of Our Kind and Joy in It] (1788–1789). It is here not, as has been said and repeated, one of the ordinary spokesmen for Enlightenment and the doctrine of felicity who has the word. Rothe is influenced by men such as Herder and Jacobi. He was thinking of laying down his pen when Herder’s *Ideen* appeared, but yet took courage to walk in his footsteps. He is clear that neither man’s nobility nor his happiness can be judged merely by his enlightenment. Free humanity, working its way toward inner harmony and toward sympathy with all that is human, is for him man’s vocation. Social life develops out of the free and undisturbed urge of hearts, not out of need and misery, nor out of pure reason. And like his two German masters he finds in immediate feeling an organ for the highest: by a revelation of nature, not through handed-down articles of faith or by the way of pure reason, we discover our own being as caused by an eternal being, and therewith the causal law itself is given in its inevitability. All philosophy is therefore theology. The doctrines of positive religion are interpreted according to the doctrines of nature’s revelation, which experience too confirms; Newton’s demonstration of the lawfulness of nature leads back to nature’s springing from the will of a single being; he has given us the physico-theology that so gloriously characterizes our enlightened age.

Kant’s teaching belongs (like Spinoza’s, Berkeley’s, and Hume’s) to “the dark philo-

sophical systems.” It shakes the empiricist philosophy on which alone we can build with security. — It is evidently partly Kant’s discussion of the causal principle as not immediately given or evident, partly his critique of the proofs of God’s existence, that repels Rothe. He is sure that when Kant has closely determined how far strict knowledge goes, then men will feel that they cannot be content with it, and will work their way out of the dark labyrinth into the clear daylight of immediate assurance.

Rothe represents a standpoint that otherwise does not come forth here at home at the close of the eighteenth century. He lacks Herder’s originality and Jacobi’s remarkable union of criticism and pathos, and his sentimentality and artificiality contrast strongly with their assertion of the right of the involuntary and the immediate in the life of the spirit. But it was not without significance that a tone of this kind too, weak and sometimes false though it was, came to sound among the many voices of the age here at home. —

Rothe had received influence not only from German writers, but also from French literature. It was especially the Genevan Charles Bonnet, the naturalist and philosopher,¹⁸ who inspired him and was his guide in the contemplation of nature. He embraces Bonnet’s doctrine of preformation, according to which each species was created for itself and in such a way that the germs of all later individuals were contained in the first representatives of the species. All beings form one great chain, but the links in this chain of nature remain through the ages specifically (“according to kind”) distinct, and no transformation of the species or transition from one species to another takes place. The original dispositions in nature cannot be annulled by any mechanical force. Man is perfect in his first disposition, but external circumstances, great upheavals of the Earth, have intervened inhibitingly and altered the disposition, so that a long and laborious development became necessary. At every stage of development, however, it holds that a being attains the satisfaction it is possible for it to reach. Through this consideration the harmony of existence asserts itself for Rothe’s thought. He expressly rejects the way out that Eilschow and Kraft (following Leibniz and Wolff) had seized upon: to distinguish between the possibilities for the divine understanding and the actuality as it springs from the divine will. “Only one could God’s plan be; that plan was the only one that could be put into effect, for away with the foolish talk that God pondered and weighed

¹⁸Bonnet was among the foreigners supported by the Danish government under Frederik V. His still instructive psychological work *Essai analytique sur les facultés de l’âme* (of particular interest for the psychology of attention and of the will) was printed in Copenhagen in 1760 and dedicated to Frederik V. Though a republican, he praised the Danes as fortunate in having such a monarch: “Ce republicain envieroit le sort de l’heureux Danois, si un citoyen de Genève pouvoit envier quelque chose!” [This republican would envy the lot of the happy Dane, if a citizen of Geneva could envy anything!]

and chose!” “What could be in God’s realm of creation, that is there. What could subsist, that subsists.” Why influences (or, as Tyge Rothe says, “impacts”) hinder the unfolding of the dispositions, of that, according to Rothe, one can give no explanation. For our sake the eternal laws are not altered; nor are they given for our sake. But this thought does not darken Rothe’s bright view of things. — Optimism is rising — from Holberg through Eilschow and Kraft to Tyge Rothe. —

Whereas Rothe conceives development as merely the unfolding of original germs, Johannes Boye (born 1756, died 1830) stands as a philosopher of development in the more modern sense of the word. In his remarkable work *Statens Ven* [The Friend of the State] (1792 ff.) he lays down the thought that everything endowed with force, man included, must struggle with resistance and violence to reach its goal. No one sleeps himself good, but every step forward toward perfection must be won by struggle. Only through strife and labour is man helped forward to what he is. A struggle of all against all is waged. Bravery was a virtue before piety became one, and physical superiority prevailed before spiritual superiority could be exercised. Nature brings up its children strictly — but thereby it brings up heroes. The lazy and the weak are pushed aside in that strife of forces through which order and harmony are won. This blessed strife is the means that Providence uses for the realization of the world-plan.

Right and morality depend on the development of culture, and it is the annals of history, not speculative vapouring, that can teach us something about their origin. Man has developed from an animal state and from brutality, through all degrees of culture, to the height he now occupies. And the state is the most important aid to culture. The life of the state is grounded on the understanding of the necessity of renouncing some of one’s rights in order to preserve the others. Through social life and by the aid of language man has ceased to be an animal; without them we should still be living among the animals in the forest and eating acorns with them. But development does not halt at a self-limitation in expectation of reciprocity. The fundamental urge in us is first satisfied in sympathy and noble self-feeling. Man then feels himself as part of a whole; his thought gazes out over wider circles, and his interest is extended far beyond his own self. At this standpoint virtue is its own reward. Even self-sacrifice becomes possible only through the urge to use the great force led by sympathy. —

From this standpoint Boye combats the critical philosophy’s attempt to build morality and right on pure reason. This philosophy halts, he says, at an unreconciled opposition between pure reason and the psychological motives. “A good will” must, after all, be a will that is good toward someone, and should love of humanity be reprehensible because

in it man follows a deep urge? The ideas of the good and the right develop out of human interests and their conflict. —

Boye's line of thought, here given in condensed form, does not come into its own in his books and is therefore easily misunderstood by superficial readers. It is a manly and free view that stirs in him, and it had not deserved the oblivion that has become its lot, but which is explained by the spirit of the age, which was first facilely optimistic and soon after rapturously Romantic. Yet Boye lacked sufficient historical sense and sufficient material to give his ideas a thorough foundation.

A. S. Ørsted, who in his prize essay answered Boye's attack on Kant's ethics, acknowledges his work as "spirited and tasteful." He agrees with Boye that the most probable hypothesis is that humanity in its childhood did not stand high above the animals — an assumption that Kant too had put forward (in his essay *Muthmaaslicher Anfang des Menschengeschlechts*, 1786). But he impresses the difference between the historical development of knowledge or of conscience and the philosophical demonstration of the presuppositions on which all knowledge and all conscience build — or between the beginning of knowledge and its foundation. — Ørsted is right that Kant's opponents constantly overlooked (and in part still overlook) this difference; but Kant has undeniably himself contributed much to the misunderstanding, especially by not giving the psychological and historical inquiry its due. —

Børge Riisbrigh found in his advanced old age the time and the inclination to discuss the philosophy that supplanted the doctrine he had proclaimed throughout his long university activity. And he does it with an acuteness and an impartiality that do him honour. His inquiry appeared in the Transactions of the Society of Sciences in 1803,¹⁹ the same year in which he withdrew from his teaching activity, and it is still of interest. He shows first that already before Kant men had been aware that what our knowledge presupposes and applies in its investigation of objects cannot, at the very moment of application, have come from the objects themselves, but must have been in the mind beforehand, whether in its first origin it stems from experience or not. There is, then, a "pre-experiential knowledge" (knowledge *a priori*). But Kant first sought the source of these principles in the human mind itself and showed their purely formal character,

¹⁹Its title is: "Undersøgelse om og hvorvidt deres Mening er grundet, som holde for, at sand Filosofi og et fuldstændigt Begreb om sand Filosofi først i vore Tider ere blevne til" [Inquiry whether, and how far, the opinion is well founded of those who hold that true philosophy and a complete concept of true philosophy have first arisen in our times]. — Philosophy was not among the subjects represented in the Danish Royal Society of Sciences from its founding (1742). Only under A. P. Bernstorff's presidency were (1795) "the properly philosophical sciences, or the so-called speculative philosophy, which in recent times has acquired so much importance," added to the mathematical, physical, and historical subjects. C. Molbech: *Det kongelige danske Videnskabernes Selskabs Historie i dets første Aarhundrede*, p. 283.

and gave a catalogue of them. He thereby laid the foundation of a new science within philosophy, the scientific critique of reason. But he did not, like some of his successors, assert that before him men had neither true philosophy nor knew what philosophy was. And he by no means spurned experience; he assumed both an experiential and a pre-experiential philosophy.

Riisbrigh wishes, as a counterpart to Kant's inquiry into pure reason, an inquiry into empirical reason, and he thinks that one would then come to see its great significance. One would then again appreciate what Socrates, Aristotle, Bacon, and Locke had taught. On behalf of science, indeed of all human culture, one must warn against undervaluing the science of experience. Our inquiry must, after all, occupy itself with objects other than its own forms. And on the other hand these forms are themselves something given: the mind has as little given itself its essential forms as it has produced the forms in the world of sense! —

In the same volume of the Transactions of the Society of Sciences that brought Riisbrigh's essay, there is an essay by the philologist and archaeologist Niels Schow (born 1754, died 1830) that likewise presents no small interest.²⁰ The author finds Kant's significance especially in the movement in thought that he had aroused; whereas he finds the critique that G. E. Schulze had directed at Kant's philosophy (especially in *Kritik der theoretischen Philosophie*, 1801) altogether decisive. It is especially the critique of Kant's strange concept "Ding an sich" [thing in itself] that is at issue. Schow maintains that whether the absolute reality whose existence we know is contained in the subject or in the object, or in what relation it stands to both, we do not know; we only trace its effects. It exceeds the limit of human reason to give a positive determination. Even the most sublime philosophical presentations — like Spinoza's — are here anthropomorphisms. The task of philosophy is to determine the limits to which our knowing is ever subject — to discuss the results of the science of experience in their significance for the ultimate questions — and to work toward a harmony between acting and knowing. Beyond the hypothetical we do not come.

Already several years before Riisbrigh's and Schow's essays appeared, Niels Treschow (born 1751, died 1833), in Kristiania, where he was then headmaster, had delivered lectures on Kant's philosophy²¹ and given a critical assessment of it that went deeper than any of

²⁰Its title is: "Den nuherskende Skepticisme eller Kritik i Filosofien kan, naar den grunder sig paa den menneskelige Fornuft og rigtigt anvendes, ej være farlig, hverken for videnskabelig Cultur eller Moralitet" [The now-prevailing skepticism or criticism in philosophy cannot, when it is grounded on human reason and rightly applied, be dangerous, either to scientific culture or to morality].

²¹*Forelæsninger over den Kant'ske Philosophie* [Lectures on the Kantian Philosophy]. Copenhagen 1798.

the hitherto mentioned works on this subject. In a clear and lively presentation Treschow gives a survey of Kant's philosophy and attaches to it his critical remarks. He finds the derivation of the pure forms of the understanding unsatisfactory in Kant, and shows in particular that Kant could not rightly appeal to the current logic's division of judgments when he himself alters this. And even if Kant had succeeded in finding all the forms that knowledge makes use of, it would still have to be shown what it is in the given, in the "material," that makes possible and occasions the application of a definite particular form in the individual particular case. What makes it, for example, that I see here a quadrangle, there a triangle? It cannot be derived from space as a general form of intuition. What makes it that I apply here the concept of magnitude, there the concept of cause? It cannot be derived from the understanding's general power to combine observations in certain forms (categories). There must in the things themselves lie something at the ground of the particular modes of combination. Already our sensations must teach us what nature itself has combined and what it has separated.

There is lacking, according to Treschow, in Kant's presentation of the forms of thought (the categories), such important concepts as likeness (identity) and difference, agreement and conflict, which are nevertheless applied in all thinking, and which are just as much applied to the given as the concepts of magnitude and of cause. And the said concepts are even of quite special significance: the understanding's work really consists merely in the comparison of what is given in experience. It is according to the likeness or unlikeness of things, their agreement or conflict, that the understanding decides which combinations among them have validity and which not. — Treschow has here pointed to an important point in the theory of knowledge. Kant had not seen that the formal logical principles, just as much as the mathematical principles and the causal principle, are applied to the given material, so that their validity too must be examined by the critique of reason.

It is the standpoint of empiricist philosophy that Treschow maintains against Kant. He praises the Britons, who here not only have themselves come nearest to the truth and made considerable progress in knowledge of human nature, but have also become teachers for others. He upholds John Locke's standpoint against Leibniz and Kant, and reproaches the Germans for not having been willing to learn from the English. Locke was right that every form presupposes a material, and that no concepts can be formed when certain representations are not given beforehand.

But Treschow misunderstands Kant when he says that, according to Kant, the understanding forms its concepts "before any experience comes to it." It is, indeed, as A.

S. Ørsted showed against Boye, Kant's express teaching that knowledge *begins with* experience, even if not all knowledge *grounds itself on* experience. Experience itself was, according to Kant, composed of given material (the sensations) and involuntarily applied forms (forms of intuition and categories).

With the limitation that Kant establishes for our knowledge, Treschow is likewise not satisfied, as little as with the way in which Kant will have that urge satisfied which science cannot satisfy. "Kant himself cannot deny that there lies in our nature an indescribable longing to know more than he holds it possible to attain — indeed, he confesses, what is still more, that the aim of our existence necessarily demands a knowledge that we are able to attain by none of the indicated ways [those of sense-observation and of understanding]. Does he then intend to bring us back under the yoke of blind faith and the hierarchy, or is it deliberately that he, as in a heroic poem, entangles the knot in order to drive attention to the highest and earn the greater admiration by loosing it?" — Treschow despairs of Kant's art and will not build on the new foundation that Kant wished to lay for one's view of life. It is questionable to give practical reason and faith the right to overstep the limits of knowledge. How can it be proved that certain articles of faith indicate the only way in which the ethical ideas can be maintained? And if one gives up all demonstration and appeals merely to personal interest, then one opens the door to disputes of faith and persecutions. About that which is only to have practical significance, everyone — and not least those in power — will think they have a voice. — Treschow's misgivings are not unfounded. Another question is whether Kant is not right that what is decisive for every view of life is in the end a personal urge arising from the experience of life. With this every faith, whether it supports itself on science or not, must be able to accord. The great thing in Kant is precisely the art with which he tightens the opposition between the power of thought and the urge of life. He only did not see that the urge of life cannot once for all be shown to have found its satisfaction in the dogmas of "natural religion," any more than in those of any other religion. —

Treschow, whom we have here met only as a critic, we shall later meet as a distinctive and independent thinker who in several directions exercised a considerable influence on Danish intellectual life.

4. Henrik Steffens

It seems to be a strife that recurs at the close of every century, when the new century begins. In Weimar there was no doubt as to when the nineteenth century began; it was celebrated by Goethe, Schiller, Schelling, and Steffens when the clock struck twelve on the evening of 31 December 1800. This little circle characterizes the transition between the two centuries. The eighteenth century had been the age of criticism and rationalism. But men such as Rousseau, Lessing, and Herder, Kant, Goethe, and Schiller pointed beyond their time by their sense for the original, the natural, the genial — for the deep-lying forces whose essence is never wholly exhausted in the forms that an age or a century is able to give it. These men represent the work and the struggle of the new humanistic Renaissance. And just as high as they stand above the eighteenth century's common rationalism, so high do they stand above the so-called Romanticism that marks the nineteenth century's first reaction against its predecessor. It was the ideas of the said men that were now, in the philosophy and poetry of Romanticism, carried out into the forms of speculative thought and rapturous imagination. Romanticism builds on their intellectual work, at the same time as it marks a certain reaction against it. Thus the two youngest participants in that New Year's celebration, Schelling and Steffens, mark a reaction against Kant's manly assertion of the independence and self-limitation of thought, at the same time as they wish to build on the foundation he had laid.

While France and England contended for world domination, in the North men immersed themselves in the world of ideas and imagination. Schiller had struck the note in his poem at the beginning of the new century:

Freiheit ist nur in dem Reich der Träume,
und das Schöne blüht nur im Gesang.

[“Freedom is only in the realm of dreams, and the beautiful blooms only in song.”]

As regards Denmark, there had in the last decades of the eighteenth century been a lively discussion of public affairs, and a keen sense of political freedom had developed. Sneedorff, Tyge Rothe, Birckner, and Johannes Boye bear witness to it. But the hope that

Birckner especially had entertained, that absolute monarchy and absolute freedom of the press could be united, was dashed, and the general European reaction penetrated also across our country's borders. It was a pressure from Russia's side that gave the decisive impulse to the appearance of the press ordinance of 1799, which stopped the free discussion.²² Remarkably quickly minds settled to rest²³ — partly in the world of philistinism, partly in that of Romanticism. Those who sought beyond the torment of the day, or sought consolation for the misfortunes that soon broke in over the country, found what they sought in the world of speculation and imagination.

And yet — for the Danes, who had had neither a Kant nor a Goethe, it was a great spiritual treasure that was opened with the new spiritual current called Romanticism. Our literature, our life of thought, and our poetry were reborn a second time. The time after Holberg had, as regards originality, been a trough between waves. Now it went upward again, and here as in Holberg's time the new was taken up and worked over in an independent way. The people set its own stamp on what it appropriated.

It was Henrik Steffens who first proclaimed the gospel of Romanticism in Denmark. Born in Stavanger (1773), and thus a Norwegian like Holberg and Treschow, he nonetheless lived his childhood in Denmark and studied in Copenhagen and in Kiel. The great spiritual movement in Germany drew him to itself, and after a rich intercourse with the greatest minds of the age in the fields of poetry, natural research, and philosophy, he returned in 1802 to Copenhagen, where in the winter of 1802–1803 he delivered his famous lectures, which are in part available in print (*Indledning til filosofiske Forelæsninger* [Introduction to Philosophical Lectures], Copenhagen 1803).

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The word “romantic” (or, as was earlier said, “romanic”) seems to have come from England to France and Germany. It comes from “roman,” a fanciful tale of the kind that first developed among the Romance peoples. At first it was used in a disparaging sense: wild, fantastic, lawless — later, especially from Rousseau's time, in a laudatory sense.

²²See on this: Edvard Holm: *Den offentlige Mening og Statsmagten i den dansk-norske Stat i Slutningen af det attende Aarhundrede* [Public Opinion and the Power of the State in the Dano-Norwegian State at the Close of the Eighteenth Century] (University Programme, 1888), p. 175 f.

²³The Norwegians took the matter up in a more energetic way than the Danes, and they also soon got a great political task. “For Norway the seed that had been strewn at the close of the eighteenth century acquired power to germinate, when the thought of the necessity of a free constitution came to coincide with the question of leading an independent political life. Most of the more considerable men of Eidsvoll had, as young people in Copenhagen in the [seventeen-]nineties, received their first awakening impressions in a political respect.” E. Holm, *op. cit.*, p. 183 f. — Grundtvig once stated, in a conversation with Sibbern, that the movement in the last decade of the eighteenth century was not allowed “to run the life out of itself.” It rose again a generation later. (Sibbern: *Dikaosyne*, 1843, p. 9.)

The word is found used of the Alps — first in the first, then in the second sense.²⁴ It denotes the opposite of the clear, the definite, the surveyable, and the intelligible, and is used first of landscapes and of human characters. It has become the standing expression for the fundamental mood and the way of thinking in Germany and in the North in the first generation of the nineteenth century.

Romantic is the infinite, that which leads out beyond all limitation, so that the mind's longing can wholly unfold itself. The romantic forms the opposite of the classical in art and of the rational in thought.

Romantic is the far-off, which awakens melancholy and longing, especially the far-off in time, the old times that have long since vanished. The age of Romanticism lived — or thought it lived — in the memory of the great and valuable that was past, whereas the eighteenth century lived in joy over what had come, or in hope of what was to come. Antiquity and the Middle Ages stood for Steffens in mystic radiance as times in which the oppositions that now divide life had not yet appeared — “in which science, art, and action, in unceasing union, were able to bring forth the most divine and highest” — and he asked: “Is not the most beautiful and glorious thing that permeates our age the sense for that old, vanished one?”

What one longed back to was especially, as is seen from the cited utterances, the gathered, concentrated way in which life, the spiritual as the material, could be led before the division of labour had intervened dividingly. Rousseau and Schiller had already energetically brought forward the unfortunate consequences of the division of labour, and not least on this point are they the forerunners of Romanticism. Steffens states (in his seventh lecture) that what especially distinguished that vanished time was the unity of what we must now separate as word and deed. “In living action everything was expressed that we now seek by words — all the revolutions and developments of nature, all the mysteries of religion. Life itself, fresh as it sprang from the Godhead, had immediately the meaning that we now only divine. Therefore all representations were living. No trace of the disintegrating death that in more recent times has made the sciences and poetry, and through them religion, so monstrous.”

This disintegration is now to cease, the division of labour is to be abolished, and religion, poetry, and science are again to become one! — Such was the gospel of Romanticism.

²⁴Compare on this Ludwig Friedländer's excursus in the second part of his *Sittengeschichte Roms*, 5th ed., II, pp. 245–247.

In order that philosophy may enter the service of the new gospel, the method must be changed. Steffens demands of his hearers — besides certain general knowledge and an interest in solving the riddle of existence — a capacity for the intuition of wholes, which lets all particulars stand as members of an absolute whole. He wishes to give “a living system, not a dead classification” — wishes to “open a more significant view over life and existence than the one to which ordinary experience in daily life, hemmed in by finite need, leads us. From the deeper view over nature, history, and our innermost temper, the philosophical problem springs as from its proper source.”

But the whole cannot be reached by the piling up of particulars, by an aggregate of facts, such as naturalists and historians as a rule give us. If they bring about a connection between the separated parts, it becomes only a quite external, mechanical connection. For the particular is understood only in connection with the whole, and therefore an intuition of the whole forms a necessary presupposition for any occupation with particulars. And in all great, foundational researches there stirs, accordingly, such an intuition, even if only in the form of instinct or presentiment. — In Steffens’ own studies he was animated — as he says in his autobiography — by a dark presentiment of an all-embracing life, long only as free imagination and of more poetic than scientific significance.

It was Romanticism’s fateful error that it was so sure of the validity of its presupposition that it did not apply the right means to work its way step by step toward the great goal that was set by the presupposition of the unity of existence. It revelled in the idea of this goal instead of being animated by it to an absorption in the particulars. Since mechanical natural science, which for two hundred years had shown how manifold changes in nature could be explained as motions produced by pressure, impact, or attraction, did not seem to satisfy the romantic ideal, it was regarded as an aberration. Science, Steffens complains, has closed nature to us; the key to nature’s secrets can be found only in the interior of our own spirit. Nature must be regarded as the prehistory of the spirit and read from above downward. — Instead of the analogy on which natural science had hitherto supported itself — the analogy between change and motion — Steffens will therefore set another: the analogy between changes in nature and psychological processes. Nature is to be seen as a series of stages by which the slumbering spirit successively awakens to consciousness. Romanticism has its justification against a materialistic dogmatism (or, as it has been called, “a mechanical mythology”), but the analogy it will set in place of the natural sciences’ fruitful mechanical analogy can lead only to poetry, not to science. —

One might think that if nature is to be the prehistory of the spirit, there must be talk of a real development, a development in time, as in the modern doctrine of evolution. But

Steffens expressly declares it a false hypothesis to assume a real, actual transition from one life-form to another. He acknowledges that it is a presentiment of nature's unity that stirs in the naturalists who embrace such an assumption; but here this presentiment has led astray. The apparent becoming of new forms is only a semblance, arising from the relativity of all oppositions. As Steffens says in a later German work: "Die Stufenfolge der Formen ist nur für den Schein" [The gradation of forms is only for appearance].²⁵ The difference of time was, for the romantic consciousness, too external to have decisive significance. One felt oneself so deeply into nature that one was equally at home in all forms and saw each of them as an eternal expression of the One that reveals itself in all.

Nevertheless Steffens lays great weight on the difference between the various forms of nature, and he finds it especially in the different degree of individuality that the various beings possess. There expresses itself in nature an individualizing tendency, which reaches its high point in man. In him and through him nature's centre-seeking, inwardizing tendency reveals itself. Man has a whole world over against him; but therefore a whole world also reveals itself in his interior. The prehistory of the spirit is here concluded — at the very point from which we must set out in order to understand the other beings of nature. The last section in the German work that underlies the Danish lectures²⁶ has for its heading: "Durch die ganze Organisation sucht die Natur nichts als die individuelleste Bildung" [Through the whole organization nature seeks nothing but the most individual formation]. Through reproduction, irritability, and sensibility, organic nature approaches — by means of increasing individualization — the realm of intelligences, and everything that shows itself there already lies as slumbering disposition in unconscious nature. — In his autobiography (*Was ich erlebte* [What I Experienced], Book Ten) he even says: "What I call philosophy of nature is nothing other than the conviction that in everything that is an object of research there must be acknowledged something distinctive, something that develops out of itself."

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Steffens did not come to continue his activity here at home. People would not have that visionary as a teacher for the young. He went to Germany and became professor at Halle, later at Breslau, and finally at Berlin, where he died in 1845.

The romantic unity of poetry, religion, and philosophy later became not enough for him. He saw that this ideal of youth could be realized only slowly and by scattered ways,

²⁵*Grundzüge der philosophischen Naturwissenschaft*. Berlin 1806, p. 187 (cf. 170).

²⁶*Beiträge zur inneren Naturgeschichte der Erde*. Freiberg 1801, p. 275 ff. — The work is dedicated to Goethe and "laid with holy awe in the Delphic temple of the higher poetry."

and the urge to immerse himself in great subjects with his whole soul, which in his youth had led him to speculation about nature, later led him to embrace the Lutheran doctrine. His soul found rest in religious faith, and religion now became for him the only point of light in the chaos of history. (*Was ich erlebte*, Book Eight.)²⁷

By his thought he exercised a considerable influence, especially through Sibbern, who came into a close relationship with him at Halle and at Breslau. It is especially Steffens' strong assertion of the individual²⁸ that is traceable in later Danish philosophizing — especially in the line Sibbern–Poul Møller–Kierkegaard.

To the history of poetry belongs his influence on Oehlenschläger, which he himself has beautifully expressed thus: "I gave him to himself." On Grundtvig too he exercised a great influence, probably most by the second, unpublished series of lectures, which treated poetry and entered upon historical-philosophical considerations. The common opposition to rationalism was a point of union; and Grundtvig stated (in a letter to Ingemann in 1824) that his own poetic-historical tendency was a continuation of Steffens' from 1803. Yet he felt a great opposition between them and declared at the same time that they were poles apart. What especially caused the separation was that Steffens would have nothing at all to do with Grundtvig's ideas about "the North's, and especially Denmark's, spiritual conditions and deep historical importance"; such thoughts were in Steffens' eyes "Judaism" — but for Grundtvig, Denmark was precisely "history's Palestine, the nation-land where Christianity is to attain its highest earthly transfiguration."²⁹

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There were two young Danish men who needed no awakening from the apostle of Romanticism: the Ørsted brothers. In quiet they had themselves appropriated what the new tendency could bring of value. Themselves having come from the best and deepest in the eighteenth century's intellectual development, they stood, by their great self-labour, more freely toward the newer tendency — on the whole, two of the most many-sided minds that Denmark has produced. We shall return to them later. Here shall be cited only an utterance of H. C. Ørsted about Steffens in a letter to Oehlenschläger (1 November 1807), who had become angry and unjust toward his former friend:

²⁷Compare the detailed characterization I have given of Henrik Steffens in my *Mindre Arbejder* [Minor Works], Second Series, pp. 162–180. — To his fine edition of Henrik Steffens' *Forelæsninger* (1905), Mr. B. T. Dahl has attached an interesting essay: *Nogle Sider af Henrik Steffens' ydre og indre Liv* [Some Aspects of Henrik Steffens' Outer and Inner Life]. —

²⁸It was also on this point that Steffens influenced Schleiermacher: compare *Den nyere Filosofis Historie* [The History of Modern Philosophy], 2nd ed., II, p. 193 f.

²⁹In the letter to Ingemann referred to (see *Grundtvigs og Ingemanns Brevveksling 1821–1859*, p. 35), Grundtvig mentions an "ultimatum" that he sent Steffens (after the latter's visit to him in 1824). This is now printed in Fr. Nielsen: *Grundtvigs religiøse Udvikling*, pp. 239–243.

“As for Steffens, I know very well that he wishes to squeeze nature into a system, and that a very narrow one. God preserve me henceforth from becoming a Steffensian... With a rare manifoldness, though not depth, in his knowledge, he unites manifold happy insights. When one does not take these for incontrovertible results of the deepest philosophy, but for what they are — flashes of lightning for guidance — then one learns much from him. Thus I have done, and can without danger continue to do.”

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5. Hans Christian Ørsted

A ferment such as Romanticism must prove its justification by the development, and especially by the work, it leads to. No one was so well prepared to receive the awakening influences of the new current, without yet being entangled in it, as Hans Christian Ørsted.

Born in Rudkøbing (1777), where there was very little access to instruction, he had to procure for himself, by self-study and by collaboration with his brother a year younger, the knowledge he needed to become a student. There followed then some rich years of youth in Copenhagen. His many-sided interest showed itself in that — while pursuing his pharmaceutical study — he won the prize for an aesthetic and a medical essay and eagerly studied Kant's philosophy, an interest he shared with his brother. But while the latter interested himself most in Kant's ethics and philosophy of religion, it was Kant's conception of the knowledge of nature and its presuppositions that especially interested him. In *Filosofisk Repertorium* (1798) he published an essay on *Naturfilosofiens første Grunde* [The First Principles of the Philosophy of Nature], in which he first gives a survey of Kant's work *Metaphysische Anfangsgründe der Naturwissenschaft* and then develops his own conception, especially through a critique of the atomic theory, which will still have interest. Remarkable it is, however — but characteristic of the age — that although the said work of Kant is already more dogmatic than Kant's own theory of knowledge permitted, the young author nonetheless thought he had to go a step further. Kant's method consisted in constantly asking on what presuppositions scientific experience rests, and it was by this way that in his said work he thought he could establish that there could be only two moving fundamental forces in the material world, an attracting and a repelling one. A material point can, he thought, act on another material point only in a straight line between the two points, and here only two motions are possible: one by which the two points approach one another, another by which they move apart. To this Ørsted fully subscribes, but he thinks that Kant's line of thought leads only to a hypothesis, because it consists in an inference back from experience. Ørsted will instead derive all natural laws "from the nature of our cognitive faculty, which Kant has

so excellently developed in his *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*.” But he overlooks that Kant, in this his principal work, had precisely impressed that it was only the fundamental presuppositions of experience that found their explanation in the very nature of human knowledge, while the particular natural laws had to be found out hand in hand with experience itself: Kant’s *Metaphysische Anfangsgründe der Naturwissenschaft* deviates in this respect from the principal work.

When Ørsted wrote the said essay, in which he wished to be more Kantian than Kant himself, Schelling’s first works on the philosophy of nature had already appeared. But against them Ørsted takes a decided stand. He states: “These books certainly deserve attention for the beautiful and great ideas one finds in them, but they lose much of their value on account of the not quite strict method by which the author mixes in empirical propositions without sufficiently separating them from the a priori propositions — especially since the empirical propositions he adduces are often fundamentally false.”

A few years after the appearance of this essay came Ørsted’s years of travel as well as his first experimental works. Already before the journey he had begun his teaching activity at the university (1800), which was to become of such great significance for Danish science and intellectual life, as well as for our material culture. We shall not here follow his development in detail, but shall keep especially to the book in which, in his old age, he gathered his conception of natural science and its significance for one’s view of life and of the world: *Aanden i Naturen* [The Spirit in Nature]. This book, unique in our literature, appeared in the year 1850, but it consists of essays written at various times, and it bears witness to the coherence in Ørsted’s life and thought from the days of youth to old age’s retrospect on the work.³⁰

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While Steffens complained that science concealed the spirit of nature from us, Ørsted wished precisely through science to penetrate into the spirit of nature. It was his conviction that it was the same reason that expresses itself in outer nature and in our own thinking and feeling. What is abiding in nature is the laws. In a waterfall the abiding thing is not the individual bodily parts, but the law that binds them, their motions and the effects of these — the scattering of the drops, the formation of foam, the sound caused by the plunging, the roaring, and the foaming — together into a single act of nature. We notice not merely a manifoldness, but a co-foldness, which expresses a thought of nature,

³⁰In the work *Vort Folk i det nittende Aarhundrede* [Our People in the Nineteenth Century], edited by V. Østergaard (1897), I have given a characterization of the Ørsted brothers of a more popular kind than the one I give of the two men in the present work.

an idea. A thing's essence is the sum of the co-operating natural laws by virtue of which it subsists. The natural laws are in nature what thoughts are in our spirit.

The Kantian has here become a Romantic. Kant had found only an analogy between our thoughts and their passing into one another through inference on the one side, and the processes of nature on the other. Ørsted, like Schelling and Steffens, makes this analogy into identity. But his "dynamic" conception of nature, according to which matter is not a dead being subsisting for itself, but manifestations of activity determined and limited by the laws of nature, he had already won through the study of Kant.

The religious expression for "the spirit in nature" is God. For the fundamentally active and the ordering in nature are not two different things, but one infinite, living reason. God's will is religion's expression for the eternal laws of existence. And, as Ørsted elsewhere expresses himself: "the eternal, living reason we call God, when we regard it in its self-consciousness, its personality." The opposition between God and the world really holds only when by the world one understands that in finitude which removes us from God. In the highest moments the opposition falls away, in that what one calls the world stands as an effect of the Godhead.

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When Ørsted conceived matter as derived from force — when in his work *Den almindelige Naturlæres Aand og Væsen* [The Spirit and Essence of General Natural Science] (1811, reprinted 1847) he taught that matter is nothing other than space filled by nature's fundamental forces, and that what gives things their unalterable peculiarities is the laws according to which they are produced — he has thereby stated a view that in the more recent history of physics has received increasing confirmation. Physics has more and more developed into a doctrine of natural forces. With the cited statement of Ørsted from 1811 may be set alongside a statement of Faraday from 1846: "Neither in what is called empty space nor in bodies can I discover anything but the forces and the lines according to which they act." Professor Christiansen sees in Ørsted's thoughts on this point "a foreboding of what a distant future was to bring."³¹

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Despite the sharp judgment that Ørsted in his day passed on Schelling's and Steffens' philosophy of nature, he too nevertheless sometimes came upon fantastic analogies

³¹Chr. Christiansen: *H. C. Ørsted som Naturfilosof* [H. C. Ørsted as Philosopher of Nature] (Overviews of the Danish Society of Sciences, 1903), p. 488.

and combinations. Thus when he sets the cardinal points of the compass alongside oxygen, hydrogen, carbon, and nitrogen, and finds an agreement between the electrical figures and the organic forms. But there was one thought that the romantic philosophy of nature had uttered, and that guided Ørsted in a fruitful way in his more specialized investigations – it was the thought of the kinship and connection of the forces of nature. This thought he pursued in detail. It led him to conceive the ray of light as a series of small electric sparks. He has thereby anticipated the electromagnetic theory of light later developed by Maxwell and Hertz.³² – Of special significance for his research, however, the idea of the inner connection of the forces of nature became through this: that step by step it led him to undertake the experiments by which he (July 1820) discovered that an electric current affects the motion of the magnetic needle. With pride he could declare that this discovery was not due to chance, but was the result of long reflection. He had on this point had to correct the presuppositions he had in his youth taken over from Kant. According to the way in which Kant had systematized Newton's teaching, there could be found only two moving forces, attraction and repulsion, acting along the line connecting two material points. But if an electric current was to have influence on a magnet, the motion had precisely to go across the connecting line. That thought of the philosophy of nature he could then carry through only in defiance of the authority of Newton and Kant.³³

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As is seen from the foregoing, there was for Ørsted an intimate connection between his scientific, philosophical, and religious circle of ideas. It was also one of his life's chief thoughts that natural science should not stand isolated in human life, but should reach into thought, faith, and action. With the publication of *Aanden i Naturen* he aimed, as he openly stated, at a change in the human view of the world. He conceived the very cultivation of science as religion: it seeks, after all, that which abides under all changes – “the bond of unity which brings it about that things, in all their manifold distributions and separations, are yet not scattered apart.”

³²Compare Chr. Christiansen: *Den elektromagnetiske Lysteori* [The Electromagnetic Theory of Light] (Transactions of the Danish Society of Sciences, 1889), pp. 189–193.

³³Compare Chr. Christiansen: *Nogle Bemærkninger om Naturvidenskabernes Betydning for vor Tid* [Some Remarks on the Significance of the Natural Sciences for Our Time] (University Programme, 1905), p. 41. — As is well known, Ørsted did not pursue his discovery further. It was Ampère who first saw in the fact demonstrated by Ørsted a single example of a general law, which he carried through theoretically and experimentally. Philosophy is not to blame for Ørsted's not going further; for Ampère too was a philosopher and has a fine place in the history of philosophy. See *Den nyere Filosofis Historie* [The History of Modern Philosophy], 2nd ed., II, pp. 304–308.

In his biography of H. C. Ørsted, Carsten Hauch says of him: “It was his conviction that in a thorough conception of the real conditions of the world there lay a deeper philosophy than that found in most philosophical systems, and a truer poetry than that found in many poems; indeed, he even thought that our religious views too could thereby be set right.”

In the great, splendid letter to Oehlenschläger of 1 and 6 November 1807, in which he reads his friend the riot act because he wished to run away from school too early, he expresses himself especially on the relation between science and poetry. The thinker, he thinks, will only at the end of his wandering reach the point where the world of art begins, while conversely the poet, when he has formed his presentiments with full clarity, approaches science. He did not have Romanticism’s shyness of science and reality. And in his poem *Luftskibet* [The Airship] he himself made an attempt to show how natural science can enter the service of poetry — an attempt that, however, may precisely serve to show that it is human striving and human destiny that is the soul in all poetry: the poem is at bottom about the fate of Montgolfier, the inventor of the airship, not about natural phenomena. There is not much poetry in it, though. The poetry was in Ørsted’s own soul, in his thinking, his enthusiasm, and his work, but he was not able to lay it into his poem.

He reproached the poets for making superstition poetic, instead of finding the poetic in nature itself. And by superstition he understood the imagination that something can act in nature otherwise than according to its laws. His aim with the publication of *Aanden i Naturen* was, as he writes in a letter (8 February 1850), “to show the often over-poetic and over-credulous people of our age that the understanding, which they so frequently mistake, has the great calling to guard the sanctuary of conscience and faith — from which, to be sure, I would have a good deal of the old leaven of superstition and prejudice swept out.” Already earlier — in his address at the millennial festival of Christianity in Denmark (1826) — he had also defended the eighteenth century’s “boldly inquiring men,” over whom “certain of the proud and hard men of our time break the staff in the name of Christianity.” He did not share Romanticism’s judgment on the immediately preceding age. There was, after all, in his own development too an inner connection between what he had brought with him from the preceding century and what he had learned in the new one.

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The line of thought in the first part of *Aanden i Naturen* led to a polemic with Bishop Mynster, which especially concerned two points. — Mynster maintained that

development must have begun with an original state of perfection. But Ørsted teaches that everything in the world begins from something undeveloped and runs through a series of stages. Why it is so, he cannot say, but experience shows it. The theologians' doctrine that nature has become worse through man's sin cannot be defended. The laws of nature have not changed, and there was suffering and death in the world before man came into being. "I submit it to the dogmatists to consider how far their science's doctrine of sinfulness must in all respects be regarded as incontrovertibly correct, or might gain by a new reworking." — The other point was how far our wishes and our need can determine what is truth. Against this Ørsted expressed himself decidedly and in beautiful, heartfelt words: "Should we not be ashamed in our innermost being, if we caught ourselves wishing to have a truth other than the real one?... No, let us give the truth the honour! With it the good is indissolubly bound up. The full truth itself brings its consolation with it."

In this statement there makes itself known not only Ørsted's great love of truth, but also his bright view of life. He was a great optimist. A guarantee that the truth always brings consolation no one can provide, and besides, there may be a long way to the full truth!³⁴ But the utterance is characteristic of H. C. Ørsted's happy nature. Fredrika Bremer, the Swedish authoress, took him to task for his optimism. He promises not to forget the dark side of life. "You forced me," he writes (1849) to her, "to subject my thoughts on the misfortunes, the pain, the hideous, to a new consideration, which has not been unfruitful for me, and which I still continue. In my joy over the harmony of the whole, I shall strive to grant pain and sorrow their lawful rights!"

Thus he wrote two years before his death. His considerations hardly altered his view of life. His own life had, in the best sense, been happy. His youth's enthusiasm bore fruit in a great discovery and in the presentation of a significant view of the world, as well as in practical work for his science's influence on life (by the founding of the Society for the Dissemination of Natural Science and by the founding of the Polytechnic College). There was harmony in his personality as in his thought. The enthusiasm of youth bore fruit in the work of manhood, and old age did not lose the understanding of the thoughts of youth.

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³⁴Compare my remarks on Ørsted's statement in my *Religionsfilosofi* [Philosophy of Religion] (§ 115).

6. Grundtvig and H. C. Ørsted

[Translation pending.]

7. Baggesen and Grundtvig

[Translation pending.]

8. Anders Sandøe Ørsted

[Translation pending.]

9. F. G. Howitz

[Translation pending.]

10. Niels Treschow

[Translation pending.]

11. Frederik Christian Sibbern

[Translation pending.]

12. Poul Møller

[Translation pending.]

13. Heiberg and Martensen

[Translation pending.]

14. Søren Kierkegaard

[Translation pending.]

15. Frederik Dreier

[Translation pending.]

16. Rasmus Nielsen

[Translation pending.]

17. Hans Brøchner

[Translation pending.]